Some Tips on Writing Style and Avoiding Common Errors in Political Science Papers

Prof. Patrick Egan, New York University

As I read student papers in political science, I repeatedly encounter many of the same mistakes in style, formatting and usage. Following is a list of guidelines meant to help you avoid some of these common errors.

The rules of writing style are about 85 percent logical and 15 percent arbitrary, and they can be 100 percent frustrating. You only get better with practice and habit. The *Chicago Manual of Style Online* is an authoritative and always up-to-date resource for writing style and usage: http://www.chicagomanualofstyle.org.

Formatting and style:

- For references, use in-line parenthetical citations or footnotes, but not both. (If you use footnotes, take advantage of your word-processing software's footnote function.) Each of these techniques has a distinctive format. For a nice overview, see http://researchguides.library.tufts.edu/c.php?g=249018&p=1658283
- Footnote numbers at the end of sentences go after the period, not before:
    - **The share of U.S. residents who are foreign-born is currently at a 100-year high.[4]**
- When quotations are followed by commas or periods, the punctuation goes before the final quotation mark, not afterward. e.g.:
    - **The first line of our national anthem is "Oh, say can you see."**
    - **"You've got to be kidding me," she said.**
- References to titles of articles are in quotation marks. By contrast, references to titles of books are in italics. Titles of journals are also in italics:
    - **Robert Dahl's book, *Democracy and Its Critics***
    - **Robert Dahl's article, "Decision-Making in a Democracy: The Supreme Court as a National Policy-Maker" in the *Journal of Public Law***
- Court cases are italicized, with v. (not vs.):
    - ***Obergefell v. Hodges***

- Capitalizations can be tricky and don't always follow logical rules. If you're unsure, check the *Chicago Manual of Style*: http://www.chicagomanualofstyle.org/16/ch08/ch08_toc.html.

  Another tip when you're not sure: Google the term and see how it is capitalized at a reputable news site (*New York Times*, *Wall Street Journal*, *Washington Post*, etc.)

  Political science students should take particular note of the following capitalizations:

  - **Democrats, Republicans, Democratic Party, Republican Party**
  - **Christians, born-again Christians**

- Spell out the numbers zero through nine; use numerals to represent any number greater than nine.

- Any time you use quotation marks, use double quotes ("…") not single quotes ('…'). There is only one exception to this rule: when a quotation appears inside a quotation, like this:

  - **"Shakespeare's most memorable phrase is 'Brevity is the soul of wit,'" proclaimed the English professor.**

- The spell-check and grammar-check functions in your word processing software aren't fail-safe, but they will pick up many of your mistakes. Using these functions consistently is a no-brainer way to avoid the most obvious (and thus embarrassing) typos. Do it.

Usage:

- Avoid using the slash (/) in academic writing. It can usually be replaced by "and" or "or." And don't use the term "and/or." It can always be replaced by either "and" or "or."
- When describing your original research, it's OK to use the first person:
  - **"I collected the data by surveying 1,000 students."**
- When referring to a person or people, use "who," not "that."

  NO: **Irish-Americans that vote Democratic tend to be younger.**

  YES: **Irish-Americans who vote Democratic tend to be younger.**

- When describing social phenomena, students can be drawn to over-usage of the terms "individual" or "individuals," which can sound quite jargon-like when employed repeatedly. There are usually other words you can use that work just as well: "person," "population," "man," "woman," "resident," "member," etc.
- When two words (known as *compound modifiers*) are used to modify a noun, a hyphen is usually placed between them:
  - **a well-developed sense of self**

  The main exception to this rule is when the first word ends in "ly" (because the "ly" alerts the reader that it is modifying the next word):
  - **a highly developed sense of self**
- Before you use an acronym or abbreviation for the first time, write it out. In subsequent usage the acronym can appear by itself.
  - First usage: **"In the Middle East and North Africa (MENA) region…"**
  - Next usage: **"citizens of MENA nations tend to be…"**

- When pluralizing acronyms, no apostrophe is used:
    - **The three HMOs all raised their rates.**
    - **LGBTs tend to be more liberal than the rest of the population.**
- When an acronym's possessive (or plural possessive) is used it takes an apostrophe:
    - **That particular HMO's rate is higher this year than last year.**
    - **LGBTs' political attitudes are more liberal than the rest of the population.**
- When discussing multiple regression results:
    - We *regress the dependent variable on* the independent variables:

      I regressed income on years of education.
    - We *control for* independent variables:

      I controlled for age in exploring the relationship between education and income.
    - Regressions produce *regression coefficients*, not correlation coefficients or correlations:

      The coefficient on education is positive, indicating that income rises as educational attainment rises, controlling for age.
    - The R-squared statistic tells us *what share (or percentage) of the variation in the dependent variable is explained by the independent variables* in the regression.

Displaying data and quantitative results

- The terms "figure," "chart," and "graph" are essentially synonyms referring to an image that displays data in a non-numerical fashion. None of these words should be used to refer to a "table," which is a display of data (typically numerical data) in rows and columns.
- Display tables and figures at large enough sizes to be easily readable.
- If your paper includes tables or figures, number each in sequence and refer to each in the text. No table or figure should appear in your paper unless it is mentioned in the text. Note that numbering sequences apply to individually tables and figures, so a correct sequence might be:
    - **Table 1, Table 2, Figure 1, Table 3, Figure 2**.

  An incorrect version of this sequence would be:
    - **Table 1, Table 2, Figure 3, Table 4, Figure 5.**
- Every figure and table should have a title, and where relevant a subtitle that tells readers the source of your data and analysis. Titles, subtitles, and the figures and tables themselves should be centered on the page:

Figure 2. The Catholic Vote for Republican Presidential Candidates, 1980-2020
Source: American National Election Studies

For many class assignments, it's OK to copy and paste statistical output from your software program directly into your document. However, when you do so:

- Use a `monospaced` font, which preserves the spacing of tables and other data. Monospaced fonts available in Word and Google Docs include `Consolas` and `Courier`.
- Make sure your output is formatted single-space. Unnecessary blank lines make tables harder to read.
- Do not allow rows of tables to be broken by a new line. This may require shrinking the font size of your table text.
- If possible, keep tables from breaking across pages (it's fine to start with a blank page if needed).